

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS



INDIA - BANGLADESH - 1

MODULE - 18

OLD FRIENDSHIP

- 1 Bangladesh is the eighth largest populated country of the world.
- 2 It is one of the fastest growing economies and has been called as 'the miracle of the east'.
- 3 The deep historical bonds between Bangladesh and India have evolved from centuries of shared history, religion and culture.
- 4 The two nations were strong allies during the Bangladesh Liberation War of 1971. India was the first country to recognize Bangladesh as a separate and independent state.



OLD FRIENDSHIP

- 5 However, they developed different Cold War alliances in 1970s and 80s.
- 6 The wave of Economic Liberalisation in South Asia forged greater bilateral trade and engagement between the two countries.
- 7 India's connections with Bangladesh are cultural, social, economic and civilizational.
- 8 There are several reasons why Bangladesh is important for India.



GEOGRAPHICAL

- 1** India and Bangladesh are neighbours and are separated by Purbachal (operating zeroline) with 4096.1 km. and thus are 'natural partners'. This border is one of the longest land borders between two countries in the world.
- 2** Bangladesh's location is a strategic wedge between mainland India and seven Northeast states of Indian.
- 3** These Northeast states are landlocked and have shorter route to the sea through Bangladesh. The Siliguri Corridor, or the 'Chicken's neck' is the most sensitive 'choke-point' for the Indian Union.



GEOGRAPHICAL

- 4 Any problem in this region- terrorist attack, natural disasters etc. would completely cut off India from the seven states.
- 5 Most cities in India's northeast are close to the hinterland of Bangladesh. For many rural people of India, it is easier to find jobs in Dhaka or Chittagong. Thus, there is massive migration in the North-east.
- 6 Eastern side of Bangladesh is fertile and produces large quantities of rice. This can be moved to Tripura, Mizoram and Manipur instead of carrying food from West Bengal.



ECONOMIC

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TRADE

- 1 Bangladesh is India's biggest trade partner in South Asia. India's exports to Bangladesh in 2018-19 was \$9.21 billion and imports was at \$1.04 billion.
- 2 In comparison, Bangladesh has an unfavourable trade relation with China
- 3 It has performed better than India on social indices
- 4 According to the Asian Development Bank (ADB), Bangladesh was expected to post a growth rate of 7.5 per cent in 2018-19 against the 7.3 per cent projected for India.
- 5 India's per capita income rose by 13.8 per cent between 2013 and 2016, Bangladesh's grew by 39 per cent.



ECONOMIC

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TRANSIT

- 1 The transit route through Bangladesh to northeast will help tap the vast energy resources of land-locked regions of India.
- 2 Moreover, the navigable rivers in India's northeast that could connect West Bengal or Orissa ports pass through Bangladesh.
- 3 The maritime and land transportation can contribute to better integration of the region.



SECURITY

- 1 A friendly Bangladesh can ensure that no anti-Indian terror or insurgent activities are carried out from its soil.
- 2 A 'neutral' Bangladesh also ensures containment of an assertive China especially along the strategic sea-lanes of Bay of Bengal.
- 3 An MoU between India and Bangladesh was signed for effective implementation of a 'Coordinated Border Management Plan' in October 2016 to identify vulnerable areas that are used for criminal activities, irregular movements and smuggling.

- 4 Bangladesh pledges 'zero tolerance' against terrorism and extremism.



REGIONAL AND MULTILATERAL

- 1 India's neighbourhood policy has focused on Bangladesh.
- 2 Bangladesh is a natural pillar of the "Act East Policy" and other sub-regional groupings like BIMSTEC (Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation) and the BBIN (Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Nepal) Initiative.
- 3 Connectivity is expected to foster sub-regional cooperation and bring benefits to India and Bangladesh.



PEOPLE-TO-PEOPLE CONTACTS

- 1 To further enhance people-to-people contacts, bus and train services have started.
- 2 Buses are running from Shillong and Guwahati to Kolkata via Dhaka.
- 3 Direct passenger and goods trains have begun to operate again.
- 4 Waterways are being renovated to enable commerce through riverine routes.
- 5 A road route through Bangladesh from Kolkata to Agartala could reduce the travel time from three days to 17 hours.



- In the recent times, India and Bangladesh cooperate in several areas:

1. Political
2. Security
3. Economic
4. Geopolitical
5. Social Sectors
6. Diplomatic Missions



POLITICAL

i LAND BOUNDARY AGREEMENT

- 1 A settled boundary is an essential prerequisite for effective cross-border cooperation.
- 2 It reduces friction, helps neighbours consolidate mutually beneficial exchanges and promote confidence in building better relations.
- 3 Land Boundary discussion between India and Bangladesh includes understanding of Enclaves
An enclave is the fragmented territory of one sovereign power located inside another sovereign country.



POLITICAL

i LAND BOUNDARY AGREEMENT

- 4 After decolonisation, small populations of Indian citizens were living in territory completely surrounded by Bangladesh and vice versa.
- 5 There were 111 Indian enclaves in Bangladesh and 51 Bangladesh enclaves in India.
- 6 The Land Boundary Agreement between India and Bangladesh was ratified in 2015 after 65 years of partition and 41 years since the conclusion of the Indira-Mujibur Accord of 1974.
- 7 It was an example of long-standing issues resolved through consultation and consensus building.



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ISSUE OF ENCLAVES

POLITICAL

- 1 On August 1, 2015, through the Land Boundary Agreement, India and Bangladesh formally exchanged 162 enclaves.
- 2 Securing state control of enclave territory through exchange has always been politically sensitive.
- 3 The 119th Constitutional Amendment proposed to amend the First Schedule of the Constitution to exchange the disputed territories occupied by both nations in accordance with the 1974 bilateral Land Boundary Agreement.
- 4 The Agreement transfers 111 Indian enclaves to Bangladesh in return of 51 enclaves to India.
- 5 Each country will henceforth, administer enclaves on their territory and enclave citizens will be able to choose where they want to live and which nationality they would prefer.

ENCLAVE EXCHANGE	
UNDER LAND BOUNDARY AGREEMENT	ADVERSELY POSSESSED LAND
Total enclaves 162	
111 OF INDIA with 17,160 acres of land, 37,334 residents	5,044.72 acres India to receive 2,777 acres from Bangladesh; Bangladesh to get 2,267 acres from India
51 OF BANGLADESH with 7,110 acres of land, 14,215 residents	

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ISSUE OF ENCLAVES

POLITICAL

IMPORTANCE OF AGREEMENT

- 1** The Land Boundary Agreement is hoped to secure the long-standing boundary issues and curb the illegal immigration, smuggling and criminal acts across border.
- 2** It is expected to improve access to the under-developed north-eastern and would further enhance the developmental works in the region.
- 3** The exchange of enclaves will mitigate major humanitarian problems as the residents in the enclaves complained of basic amenities and facilities.
- 4** The settlement represents a permanent solution to the issue.



SECURITY

- 1 Ever since Prime Minister Hasina has assumed office, security situation between the two countries has enhanced immensely.
- 2 She has firmly **controlled the security situation** and did not allow any terrorist activities or any terrorist group to use Bangladesh's soil to launch an attack against India or any neighbouring country.

In 2009 India and Bangladesh signed few pacts-

1. Mutual **legal assistance** in criminal matters
2. **Combating international terrorism, organized crime and illicit drug trafficking**
3. **Transfer of sentenced persons** during the Hasina visit.



SECURITY

- 3 Improvement in bilateral ties has led to newer areas of cooperation such as cyber space.
- 4 Bangladesh has provided cyber connectivity between the international gateway at Cox's Bazar to Agartala for faster Internet connectivity in India's north-eastern states.
- 5 An agreement between the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and the Anti-Corruption Commission of Bangladesh was signed during the 5th Joint Consultative Commission (JCC) to allow bilateral coordination between the anti-corruption authorities.



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TRANSIT

ECONOMIC

- 1 There is a major push to connectivity initiatives via sea ports, inland water transport, rail and highways to enable Bangladesh to connect with Bhutan and Nepal.
- 2 Both India and Bangladesh are undertaking various measures to restore the pre-1965 rail and other connectivity links.
- 3 The Indo-Bangladesh Protocol on Inland Water and Transit was signed by the Prime Ministers of India and Bangladesh in 2015. The agreement will be renewed after every five years.



4 Bangladesh to allow use of Mongla and Chittagong seaports for movement of goods to and from India through rail and road

5 In spite of resistance from the state government of West Bengal, border trade with Bangladesh was resumed via West Bengal



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INFRASTRUCTURE

ECONOMIC

- 1 Bangladesh is the biggest recipient of India's concessional LOC.
- 2 India has extended three Lines of Credits (LOC) to Bangladesh between 2010-2020 amounting to \$8 billion for the development of infrastructure in various sectors including roads, railways, shipping and ports.
- 3 India has also been providing grant assistance for the construction of Akhaura-Agartala rail link, dredging of inland waterways and construction of India-Bangladesh Friendship Pipeline.



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INFRASTRUCTURE

ECONOMIC

- 4 In 2009, Exim Bank of India agreed to develop railways and communications infrastructure in Bangladesh.
- 5 A 35-year electricity transmission deal was signed under which India will be exporting up to 500 MW power to Bangladesh
- 6 India will be providing Bangladesh technical assistance for the construction of the 2,400 MW Rooppur Nuclear Power Plant in Pabna. West Bengal is also supplying 500 MW to Bangladesh since 2013



ECONOMIC

ii INFRASTRUCTURE

- Cooperation in connectivity, energy, security and intelligence matters has intensified.

7 The India-Bangladesh Friendship Pipeline project, of 130 km will connect Siliguri in West Bengal and Parbatipur in Dinajpur district of Bangladesh.

8 This project is expected to cost Rs 346 crore. The capacity of the pipeline will be one million metric tons per annum.

9 The dual-gauge rail lines in Dhaka-Tongi section and the dual gauge rail line in Tongi-Joydebpur section of Bangladesh Railway was inaugurated.



ECONOMIC

ii INFRASTRUCTURE

- 10** This project is expected to
- improve connectivity especially The Padma multipurpose bridge and the Akhaura-Agartala rail link
 - generate more revenue.
 - strengthen the national and urban transport
 - Waterways will reduce the cost of trade

- 11** Bangladesh has also participated in the International Solar Alliance Conference in India in October 2018.



ECONOMIC

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CHINA FACTOR

- 1 India is adopting a multi-pronged strategy to enhance trade and business partnership with Bangladesh in the backdrop of China' efforts provide Dhaka with duty-free access to its products.
- 2 India had offered duty-free access to several Bangladeshi products, that helped reduce deficit in Bangladesh's trade with India.
- 3 While Chinese trade concessions can push Bangladesh into a "dual deficit and debt trap", India is activating various connectivity initiatives for seamless movement of Bangladeshi products to the landlocked north-eastern states and other parts of India.



GEOPOLITICAL

2014 UN TRIBUNAL'S AWARD

- 1 In 2014, UN Tribunal's award had clearly delineated the course of maritime boundary line between India and Bangladesh in the territorial sea, Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) and continental shelf within and beyond 200 nautical miles.
- 2 The verdict has been positively accepted by both countries, especially given the geo-strategic/ political significance of greater Indian Ocean region and forums like BIMSTEC and as an attempt boost coastal and maritime security in the region..



GEOPOLITICAL

2014 UN TRIBUNAL'S AWARD

- 3 It is significant in the backdrop of China's close ties with Bangladesh and its growing interest in the Bay of Bengal region
- 4 It will also open doors for exploration of oil and gas in the Bay of Bengal.
- 5 Bangladesh can allow foreign firms to explore and exploit hydrocarbons in the Bay.
- 6 The verdict is also good news for fishermen as now vast areas of sea are made available to them.



SOCIAL SECTORS

- Small Development Projects (SDPs) constitute an active pillar of India's development assistance to Dhaka.

- 1 India has funded 55 SDPs, including construction of student hostels, academic buildings, cultural centres and orphanages, in Bangladesh and another 26 SDPs are being implemented.
- 2 The two sides also signed an agreement on training of mid-career civil servants from Bangladesh.
- 3 An MoU was also signed for cooperation in the field of new age and traditional medicines.



DIPLOMATIC MISSION

- 1 Bangladesh plans to open a Deputy High Commission in Chennai as it seeks to strengthen ties with the southern parts of India.
- 2 This will be Bangladesh's sixth diplomatic office in India.
- 3 Many Indians working in Bangladesh are from southern India.
- 4 Also, Bangladeshis are also visiting South India, especially for medical tourism



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